# Student who spells by blinking is denied chance to sit exam

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*Romi says the exam system should adapt so that disabled students have a fair chance*

**It takes Romi Loffler about half an hour to write a sentence, spelling it out one letter at a time by blinking.**

The 21-year-old, from Netherlee in East Renfrewshire, has Rett Syndrome, a genetic neurological disorder which leaves her unable to speak or move and comes with a range of health problems including epilepsy.

For years, people with the condition were assumed to have profound learning disabilities but Romi, who uses special eye-gaze technology to communicate, is hoping to challenge that belief.

After months of work, she completed the coursework for National 4 (Nat 4) history and achieved a qualification last year.

This year her aim was to go a step further and pass at Nat 5, which would require her sitting an exam.

But her hopes have been dashed by Scotland's exams body Qualifications Scotland (QS) which has rejected her family's requests for the adjustments Romi would need.



*Romi told the BBC she deserved the same chance as everyone else*

About 18 months before exam time, her college and parents began discussions with QS, asking if she could sit it one question at a time over a number of weeks or potentially months.

This would mean her sitting a different exam paper to other Nat 5 students but it would still be at the same level.

Her parents also asked if she could use a "bank" of pre-agreed relevant words that would mean she would not have to spell out every letter.

Qualifications Scotland (QS) said no despite two children using eye gaze technology to sit GCSE exams in England earlier this year.

One, who has cerebral palsy, took five months to complete the exam.

"If it can be done for GCSEs, I simply don't understand why it can't be done for Nat 5," says Romi's mum, Gael Gordon.

Qualifications Scotland suggested Romi sit the exam all in one go, but her mum said that would be impossible because communicating using her eyes is so exhausting.

Her mum said that QS had expressed concern that Romi would get an unfair advantage over other candidates.

“I think she is starting from a position of such incredible disadvantage that just getting her to the starting line is incredibly difficult,” her mum said.

“She is not wanting to be given it and given a pat on the head.

“She wants to sit the exam in a way she can demonstrate everything she knows.

“It is about proving her capacity and proving her worth and showing what she can do because if she gets that certificate no-one can take that away from her.”

Romi took time to spell out for BBC Scotland News how she feels about not being able to sit the exam.

“Angry,” she wrote.

“Other students got the chance to get their National 5 and I didn’t. That was unfair. I deserved the same chance as everyone else.

“They shouldn’t expect us to fit around their exam system. The exam system should adapt so that disabled students have a fair chance to show what they know.

“People sometimes underestimate what I can do because I am disabled. A recognised qualification gives me evidence of what I can do.”

Tracey Campbell, of Rett UK, said Romi had been dismissed in many areas of her life and she wanted to prove she was capable.

“To have these extra barriers put in place is completely unfair and unjust,” she said.

“What has been fabulous about exam boards in England is that people have been allowed to sit their exams over a long period of time, one question at a time.”

Glasgow Clyde College, where Romi studies, said she is “highly capable and committed”.

Claire Donaghey, assistant principal arts and continuing education, said: “Despite considerable discussion with Qualifications Scotland, the mitigating arrangements we have proposed have not been deemed compatible with these requirements.

“We remain fully committed to supporting Romi and will continue to work constructively with her, her family and Qualifications Scotland to explore every available option and achieve the best possible outcome for her.”

Qualifications Scotland said it was committed to making reasonable adjustments so that disabled learners have an equal opportunity to demonstrate their knowledge, skills and understanding.

A spokesperson said: “This year over 39,000 learners benefited from assessment arrangements.

“We also have a duty to maintain the integrity of qualifications, so must always ensure that any reasonable adjustments put in place for learners do not impact standards.”

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## 生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

| 词 | 词性 | 中文 | 备注 |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| sit | v. | 参加（考试） | “denied chance to sit exam” 被拒绝参加考试；sit an exam/paper 为英式固定说法，本义“坐”，新闻高频第二义项 |
| spell out | phr. | 逐字母拼出；详细说明 | “spelling it out one letter at a time by blinking” 靠眨眼一次拼一个字母；later “spell out for BBC Scotland how she feels” 则是第二义项“详细讲明” |
| dashed | v. | 使（希望、梦想）破灭 | “her hopes have been dashed” 她的希望落空；本义“猛冲、击碎”，被动语态常接 hopes/dreams |
| assumed | v. | 被认为、被假定 | “were assumed to have profound learning disabilities” 曾被认为有重度学习障碍；被动式 assumed to have done，阅读时勿漏“过去曾如此认为”之意 |
| profound | adj. | 严重的、深度的 | “profound learning disabilities” 重度学习障碍；此处取医学义，非“深刻的、深奥的” |
| adjustments | n. | （考试的）便利安排、调整 | “the adjustments Romi would need” 罗米所需的考试安排；“reasonable adjustments” 是英国残 |

| 词 | 词性 | 中文 | 备注 |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| | | | 障权益核心术语，意为合理便利 |
| candidates | n. | 考生；候选人 | “an unfair advantage over other candidates” 相对其他考生的不公平优势；本义“候选人”，考试语境指考生 |
| exam paper | n. | 试卷 | “a different exam paper to other Nat 5 students” 与其他学生不同的试卷；paper 为多义词：报纸 / 论文 / 试卷 |
| bank | n. | 储备库、一组备用内容 | “a ‘bank’ of pre-agreed relevant words” 一组事先约定好的词库；此处为“库、储备”义，非“银行” |
| in one go | phr. | 一口气、一次性完成 | “sit the exam all in one go” 一次性考完（文中被否决的方案）；对比 over a number of weeks |
| fit around | phr. | 围着……转、迁就 | “They shouldn’t expect us to fit around their exam system” 不应指望我们去迁就考试制度；另有“挤时间做某事”义 |
| integrity | n. | 公正性；诚信正直 | “a duty to maintain the integrity of qualifications” 维护证书资质的公正性；考试机构声明高频词 |
| mitigating | adj. | 缓解性的、起减轻作用的 | “the mitigating arrangements we have proposed” 我们提出的缓解性安排；动词 mitigate 缓解，mitigating circumstances 减刑情节 |

| 词 | 词性 | 中文 | 备注 |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| deemed | v. | 被认为、被认定 | “have not been deemed compatible with these requirements” 被认定与要求不符；官方、法律文书高频，deem sth compatible = 认定相符 |
| dismissed | v. | 被轻视、被无视 | “Romi had been dismissed in many areas of her life” 罗米在人生许多方面都被轻视；另两义：被解雇 / 被驳回 |
| underestimate | v. | 低估 | “People sometimes underestimate what I can do” 人们有时低估我的能力；反义 overestimate 高估 |
| capacity | n. | 能力、潜能 | “proving her capacity and proving her worth” 证明她的能力与价值；另一常用义“容量、载量” |
| cerebral palsy | n. | 脑瘫 | “One, who has cerebral palsy, took five months to complete the exam” 其中一名脑瘫考生花五个月完成考试；医学固定搭配 |
| eye-gaze technology | n. | 眼动追踪技术（用眼睛控制电脑） | “uses special eye-gaze technology to communicate” 用眼动设备交流；全篇关键词，亦作 eye gaze technology |
| Rett Syndrome | n. | 雷特综合征 | 一种遗传性神经发育障碍，多发于女童，影响语言与运动能力；文中 Romi 所患疾病 |